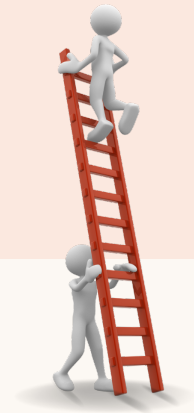


English Ladder

Teaching Guide

Explanation of "Was able to" vs. "Could"

A concise classroom guide with lesson flow, teaching cues, and a ready-to-use answer key built around the same English Ladder concept sheet.



Grammar Concepts #35

Key Points

Assurance Against Confusion:

Visual anchor

Use the concept poster to spotlight the main language pattern in **Explanation of "Was able to" vs. "Could"** and keep the explanation visible during practice and discussion.

ENGLISH LADDER

Concept #35 ► **Was able to vs Could**

We do not use "**could**" for something accomplished in the past.
Instead we use "**was able to**".

Past			Future
"was able to" Past Accomplishment	"could have" Past Possibility	"could" + "if" Future Possibility	"can" + "if"/"when" Future Certainty
I was able to pass the exam.	I could have passed the exam if I had studied.	I could pass the exam if I study.	I can pass the exam if I study.
He was able to buy a car.	He could have bought a car if he had worked harder.	He could buy a car if he works harder.	He can buy a car if he works harder.
They were able to talk to Tom.	They could have talked to Tom if they had gone to his party.	They could talk to Tom if they go to his party.	They can talk to Tom when they go to his party.

You can also use "**would have been able to talk**" here.

You can also use "**may be able to**" here.

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At a Glance

Lesson focus Explanation of "Was able to" vs. "Could"	Suggested timing 45-60 minutes
Core objective Students explain the target pattern clearly and apply it accurately in controlled practice and discussion.	Materials Student PDF, the concept image, board space, and time for partner checking.

Suggested Lesson Flow

Warm-up	Display the concept image and ask learners to predict the rule behind Explanation of "Was able to" vs. "Could" before reading the explanation.
Model	Walk through the Core Idea and the sections on Key Points, Assurance Against Confusion. Pause after each part so students can restate the pattern in plain English.
Guided practice	Project two or three examples from the concept sheet and ask pairs to explain why each choice works, not just what the answer is.
Independent work	Assign the 24 practice items for quiet work, partner checking, and final feedback.
Closure	Ask students to create one new sentence or mini-example of their own that follows the same pattern.



Likely Learner Errors

- Learners may overgeneralize the first pattern they notice. Keep returning to **Key Points, Assurance Against Confusion:** and ask students to explain what changes from one example to the next.
- Long explanations can hide the signal word or structure. Have students underline the exact phrase that tells them which form, pattern, or response is needed.
- If students can choose an answer but cannot explain it, ask them to justify their choice using words taken directly from the concept sheet.

Differentiation and Delivery Notes

- Support: teach one section at a time, then send students back to **the examples** or the practice set so they can apply the same rule immediately.
- Pair work: let students compare answers aloud before you reveal the key. The explanation step is as important as the final answer.
- Extension: ask stronger students to write two fresh examples or a short dialogue that uses the same target language accurately.

Model Language from the Concept Sheet

- Examples: Correct: I was able to pass the exam....
- Common Confusion: You might be tempted to use "could" here, thinking that since it's in the past, "could" would be appropriate....
- Examples: Correct: I could have passed the exam if I had studied....
- Common Confusion: Students might mistakenly use "was able to" when referring to missed opportunities....
- Examples: Correct: I could pass the exam if I study....
- Common Confusion: Some students may confuse "could" with "can" when discussing future possibilities....



Answer Key

Use this key for whole-class feedback or fast marking.

ITEM 01

She was able to finish the report before the deadline because she worked overtime.

ITEM 02

I could have bought that car if I had saved more money.

ITEM 03

If she studies hard, she can pass the exam.

ITEM 04

They could have gone to the concert, but they decided to stay home instead.

ITEM 05

After weeks of practice, he was able to play the guitar smoothly.

ITEM 06

If you work hard, you can achieve your goals.

ITEM 07

She could have been a great singer if she had taken lessons.

ITEM 08

They could have completed the project, but they didn't have enough time.

ITEM 09

He was able to read the entire book in one night because it was so interesting.

ITEM 10

I could have won the race, but I tripped in the final lap.

ITEM 11

If they leave now, they can catch the last bus.

ITEM 12

She was able to play the piano when she was just five years old.

ITEM 13

He could have finished the assignment, but he was too tired.

ITEM 14

If you study, you can pass the test.



ITEM 15

They can talk to the manager if they arrive before 5 PM.

ITEM 16

They were able to reach the summit before the storm hit.

ITEM 17

She could have traveled to Paris, but she chose to visit London instead.

ITEM 18

After training for months, he was able to run the marathon without stopping.

ITEM 19

If he had more time, he could have completed the task.

ITEM 20

If they practice, they can win the championship.

ITEM 21

I could have called you earlier, but my phone was dead.

ITEM 22

If she finishes her work, she can join us for dinner.

ITEM 23

She could have visited the museum, but she decided to stay at the hotel.

ITEM 24

After years of training, they were able to win the national championship.



Feedback Cues

- Item 01: Explanation: "Could" suggests possibility but not a completed action. "Was able to" confirms that she successfully finished the report.
- Item 02: Explanation: "Was able to" indicates a completed action, which did not happen here. "Could have" expresses the missed possibility.
- Item 03: Explanation: "Can" expresses certainty or high likelihood, whereas "could" suggests only a possibility.
- Item 04: Explanation: "Could" suggests they had the possibility, but "was able to" would indicate they actually went, which is incorrect.
- Item 05: Explanation: "Was able to" confirms the achievement of playing smoothly, while "could" would only suggest it was possible.
- Item 06: Explanation: "Can" suggests a strong likelihood, whereas "could" would only imply a possibility.